

Foodies: A Smith Dining Website Case Study

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1. Introduction to Site

We were interested in the demographic of Smith students in dining halls. As Smithies of color, we were particularly interested in where other POC students chose to dine. We wanted to see how the demographics of each dining hall varied based on the food offered. We hoped to explore the unique relationship POC Smithies had with Smith's food options, specifically, cultural and ethnic foods.

From Wednesday 2/21 until Sunday 2/25, we began a rapid recon of different dining halls on the Smith College campus. Each team member observed Cutter/Ziskind, Chase/Duckett, King/Scales, Compass Cafe, Tyler, and Northrop/Gillett. We took pictures to note how busy the dining hall was and took note of the general demographic of students. We then observed the menu to see if they indicated any specific dining patterns throughout campus. We noticed a positive correlation between an increased POC Smithie presence and cultural food options. However, this relationship was not reflected in all dining halls. We were curious about what factors affected this relationship and developed our research question: How do Smithies feel about Smith's ethnic foods, and how does it impact their sense of belonging?

2. Research Question & Methodology

Although our Rapid Recon originally focused on just POC students, we quickly noticed the intersection of POC and International Smithies experience in the context of food. For example, a white international student may not identify as POC, but they may share similar experiences and sentiments in Smith's inauthentic or lack of proper representation of cultural foods. On the other hand, POC students who grew up around Americanized versions of cultural foods may have positive opinions about the dining experience at Smith.

To gather data and continue our research, we created a survey on Google Forms, a survey structure frequently used by Smith students. Our survey contained questions that gauged the general thoughts and opinions of Smithies. We asked students if they identified as either or both POC or an International Student. We also provided an optional question for students to specify their ethnic background if they wished to do so. To ensure everyone who might answer has their race/ethnicity represented we included as many racial/ethnic groups as possible.

Additionally, we asked questions regarding their dietary restrictions, where and when they ate, their ratings for their meal, and if they had a favorite dining hall. We also provided a space for students to answer what they did or did not enjoy about their meal. To gain deeper insight into the impact of food on Smith students, we asked two freeform questions, "Does the food impact your sense of belonging at Smith?," and "What are your opinions on the ethnic food at Smith?"

We made the survey anonymous to gather a clear and accurate understanding of the survey participants. For our outreach, we posted posters with QR codes of the survey throughout Smith's Dining Halls, houses, and academic buildings. We wanted to gather as many responses

from Smithies of all communities on campus, so we directly sent the survey to three groups; the Latin American Students' Organization (LASO) email list, a group chat of International Students from Asian countries, and the discord channel of the Smith College K-Pop Dance Crew.



Figure 1



Figure 2

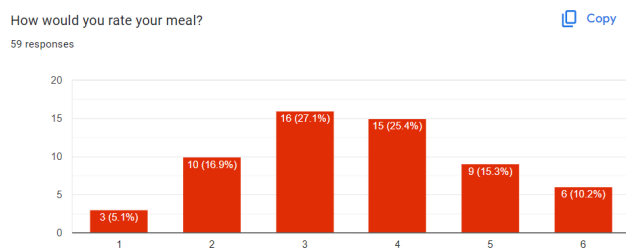


Figure 3

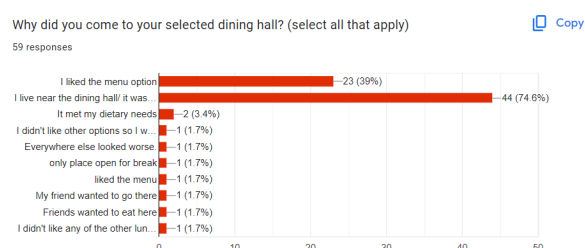


Figure 4

3. Exploratory Findings

After conducting both interviews and gathering data through surveys to better understand the sentiment of POC and International Smithies towards dining we noticed a few key student pain points. With the in-person interviews, there was a consistent thread of wanting the dining staff to be more proactive in acquiring authentic recipes for cultural foods. Our interviewees expressed a desire to simply go into the kitchens themselves and fix the issues involving not only cultural authenticity but also fixing recipe details that go unnoticed by staff. One example of this lack of attention towards recipes was pointed out by an interviewee who stated that it was almost uncomfortable and ridiculous that for Chinese dishes Smith dining would use basmati rice instead of jasmine rice and vice versa for Indian dishes. Others also took offense to how staff missed the mark on recipes even if they appreciated the attempt to diversify Smith's food with one student stating, "I just think Smith wants to incorporate many diverse foods but does not focus on the qualities of those foods. The idea is of good intent, but the execution shows a lack of respect for the cultures." This lack of attention to recipe details exacerbated the frustration

students felt towards dining which not only affected their nutrient intake for the day but also greatly impacted their own morale on campus. After voicing their frustrations many also commented that a majority of these issues could be fixed in two ways. Firstly, some students mentioned improving the communication between staff and students as current feedback forms felt very impersonal, unorganized, and that they had no idea if anyone was even making an effort to implement their feedback. The second approach is more radical as some students preferred Smith to disallow staff from cooking any more ethnic food if they continue to not put in effort.

The survey also highlighted similar sentiments to the interviews in terms of dish authenticity and improving communication between students and staff. However, a new theme seemed more prominent in the survey which involved the sense of belonging students felt in relation to Smith dining food. Many students expressed that due to the lack of visible effort put into the food they were reminded of the fact that they existed in a predominantly white space that did not wholly support them. This constant reminder that they were different from the dominant demographic at Smith impacted not only their morale but also their relationship with Smith's ethnic food. The feeling of alienation increased many students' wish to disallow Smith from cooking ethnic food in the case that the inaccurate representation of their culture's food would make other students view their cuisine and country negatively. Overall, students want to make the dining experience feel like a mutual collaborative effort where they have the ability to give recipe options for ethnic food, give detailed comments on what can be improved, and feel like their voices are being heard and not thrown into a void. Essentially a more open and mutual form of communication would make POC and/or international students feel more represented in the food and welcomed on Smith campus. From our research we were also able to create a persona named Estella and a design scenario that would help us stay centered in addressing both the pain points and hopes of our focus site as we began to create prototypes (Figures 5 and 6).

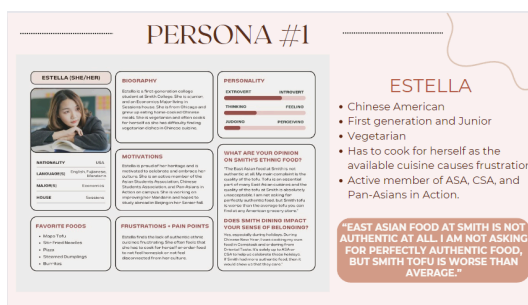


Figure 5

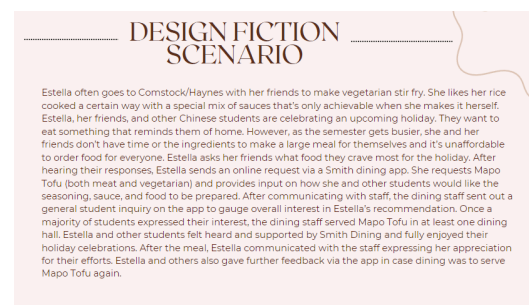


Figure 6

4. Portfolio of Design Provocations

Once we had identified the main pain points between POC/International Smithies and dining staff we began to ideate different vehicles of communication that could be implemented to mutually engage in the improvement of Smith food. Before we started developing our low-fidelity prototypes we first whiteboarded the pain points, our target audience, and different features we could focus on in three hypothetical scenarios (Figure 7). Some features we

considered were whether we wanted student feedback for each house to be a public open forum or privatized so only dining hall workers could engage with it. Ultimately we decided that for direct feedback we should make it private since it would foster a more one-on-one communication space that would be safe and comfortable for both parties. However, with the feedback we wanted to acknowledge that workers are already overwhelmed with their own work in the hall so being increasingly overwhelmed with hundreds of unorganized feedback postings would not be ideal. So we chose to implement a categorization method for all of the student inquiries. This way workers can easily access and engage with any specific topic that they have the bandwidth to comment on. Since we would be using a feedback form we did not want students to feel like they were sending it off to an impersonal void so we came to the conclusion of using a chatbot to help engage students as they fill out their form. This way students got a sense that they were already communicating with someone. It should be noted that although we want to engage student inquiries we considered making all student information anonymous for their own safety and comfort to speak authentically in their postings. Contrasting the anonymity of students we also decided to keep staff information public so students could know who they were talking to in feedback replies which we initially thought would create a personable and respectful atmosphere since students would be reminded that they are speaking with another human being.

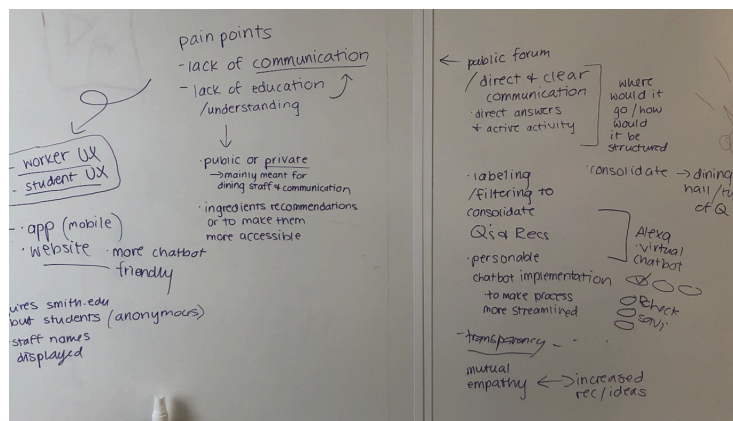


Figure 7

While on the whiteboard we found that we could split our ideated features into three low-fidelity prototypes. The two most traditional prototypes were a mobile app for students to engage with dining on the go and an extension to the Smith dining website. The third and most radical of our ideas was implementing a stream deck to gather live student feedback.

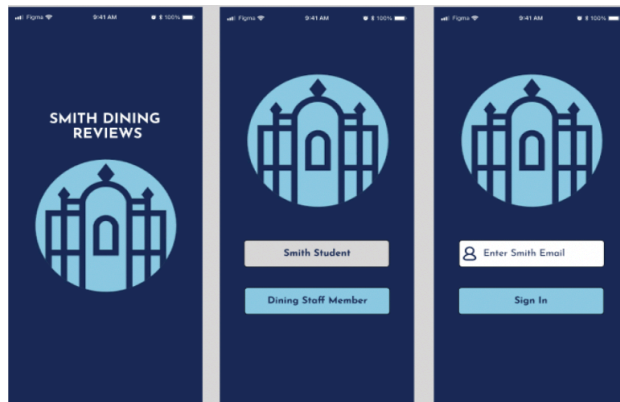


Figure 8

The idea for a mobile application arose from a hypothetical scenario involving a student wanting to quickly send feedback to the staff of a certain house without going through the hoops of getting their laptop out or going through multiple Smith web pages to find what they need. This app titled, “Smith Dining Reviews” (Figure 8) consisted of four main features which were house-specific question forums, a house-specific rating page, recipe and meal suggestions, and a chatbot for acquiring plus uploading student feedback. To make sure that communication was mutual on both ends of the app we also created two different perspectives of, “Smith Dining Reviews” for students and workers. For the student perspective, we wanted students to have access to an open question forum where they can view the name and face of the dining worker who is replying to student messages for a specific house. Along with that there is also a section for an overall dining hall rating with student commentary. Our reasoning for giving students access to these house-specific pages was to create a sense of community between students and staff and help students see which dining halls were better at creating certain recipes. This way their morale, which is impacted by food quality, could be boosted due to a more informed dining hall selection. Students would also have access to a chatbot that would acquire their feedback, recipe suggestions, and dining reviews which are either sent directly to the head of the house dining hall or to the appropriate public page. Here we once again wanted to have more personable feedback acquisition between staff and students. From the worker’s perspective, they must create an account so students are able to have a face to the person they send their feedback to which would ideally foster respect and understanding. The worker would then have access to replying to student feedback in their house forum, viewing the dining reviews, and viewing the suggested recipes. Allowing staff members to be the only ones able to view recipe suggestions would give them more power in deciding which meal would be more feasible for their hall without the added stress of students viewing the selections they made. This design provocation if expanded upon would have met the student need for transparent communication, increased morale, personable feedback acquisition, and recipe collaboration while also keeping the experience manageable for staff members.

Current Students

House Menus ▾ Hours ▾ Sustainability ▾ Current Students ▾ Campus Center Cafe ▾ Compass Cafe ▾ MORE >

Student Feedback

Student Feedback Form

Dining Hall ▾

Rating

● ● ● ● ●

Comments/Feedback:

Submit Feedback

Recipe and Meal Suggestion

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Figure 9

Our next provocation was adding an extension page to the existing Smith website which can be accessed in a similar way to the current Smith House Menus (Figure 9). The idea for this provocation arose from a scenario where a student is on their laptop looking up what the house meal options are for the day. Then, they navigate to the extension page where they are able to see any potential recipe suggestions or leave feedback for any meals they have eaten that day. This prototype consists of three main features which are a recipe and meal suggestions forum, a feedback form, and a chatbot. For this prototype, we only focused on the student perspective as we wanted to pay attention to creating a user-friendly online space that allows students to feel heard in their feedback. In the feedback form, it asks students to specify which dining hall they are leaving feedback for, a general rating, and their commentary. In this version of the form, students do not have a specified topic that they select so they are more free to express their opinions. The recipe and meals suggestions forum in this prototype is left open to the Smith public so students are able to not only upload their own recipes but also view what the dining staff has approved and commented on. This open and anonymous interaction on the forum would help foster mutual communication and transparency between students and staff while keeping both parties safe. This forum was also based on the current student forum space called *Confessional* where students are able to anonymously make commentary on all things Smith and other students are able to reply back on a thread. The chatbot serves more as a redirection helper where it is able to take students to a new page on the Smith website if they are done using the forum and feedback page or if they want to navigate to an FAQ. With this provocation, we would have been able to aid in increasing student-to-staff communication, recipe selection transparency, and increased feedback that is more qualitative rather than quantitative.



Figure 10



Figure 11

The third and final provocation we developed was a stream deck design which would act as a more interactive way for students to submit their feedback while they eat their meal (Figures 10 and 11). In this scenario, as a student is eating their food at some Smith dining hall they are able to reach over to the stream deck to leave feedback. They will be presented with three switch screens where one is for selecting their favorite food option, the second is their least favorite, and the third is the time they ate. Although this provocation does not increase the direct communication between Smith Dining and students it will provide a new form of data acquisition. Also, since students will ideally update their feedback every dining hour due to direct access to stream decks then staff will be able to figure out where their faults are and fix them more efficiently. Overall this design would aid in the pain point of feedback feeling impersonal, but it would not help in increasing communication unless another component was added to it.

5. Prototype Interaction Walkthrough

After presenting our design provocations in class, we received feedback from various groups as well as Professor Johanna. Students found our focus on direct communication between students and staff in the mobile app and website prototypes to be a great way of addressing students' pain points. However, students expressed a significant preference for the website prototype, as most Smithies already associate Smith Dining with a website, rather than an app. Students also noted a factor that we hadn't considered in our design provocations; how can we make it so that dining staff members are not overwhelmed? When creating increased contact with staff, how do we ensure dining staff are not tediously reading and responding to over 2000 feedback posts and reviews? In response to this concern, students expressed that when providing feedback and writing reviews, they took more time to think and elaborate their thoughts in a

more considerate manner on websites rather than on apps and mobile interfaces such as Confesh and Yelp. Students also suggested incorporating the different features of both the mobile app and website. By incorporating the anonymity for both students and staff from the website, along with the public and private direct communication between students and staff from the mobile app, we could tackle both students’ pain points and the potential dining staff’s pain points.

Keeping the feedback we received in mind, we decided to proceed with the website prototype. We wanted to keep the familiarity students liked about the website prototype, so each webpage we designed mimics the UI of the existing Smith College website.

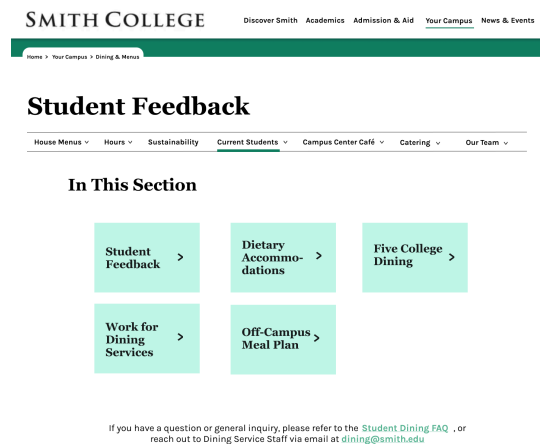


Figure 12

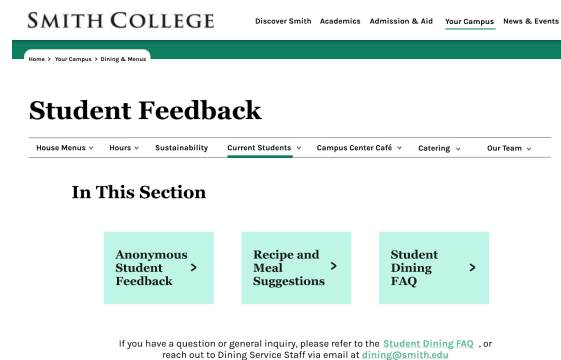


Figure 13

We added a new link for students to access the “Current Students” Section of the Dining Website. We specifically labeled it “Student Feedback” to show that the page is dedicated toward students, rather than general information (Figure 12). Within the “Student Feedback” Section, we included three links to provide two different methods of communication and a general FAQ (Figure 13).

The “Anonymous Student Feedback” allows students to specify feedback on different aspects of the dining experience. As seen in Figures 14 and 15, when students click on the “Anonymous Student Feedback” Link, it asks students to choose which dining hall and what aspect of the dining experience they would like to provide feedback on. These options range from specific food quality to generalized feedback.

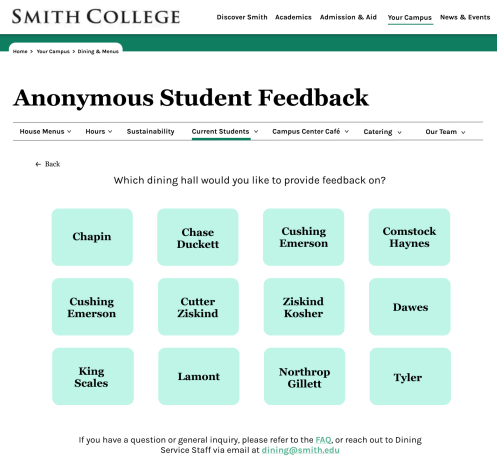


Figure 14

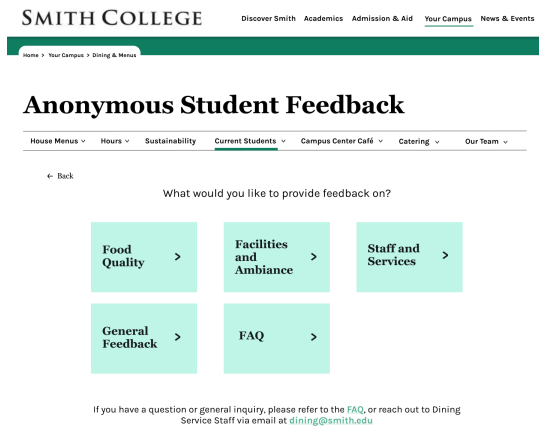


Figure 15

After specifying the nature of their feedback, students are directed to a form to write out their comments and feedback. Students may leave their email addresses if they would like a member of the dining staff to respond and continue this conversation (Figure 16). The filters at the bottom of the text box also remind students which options they chose. After students submit their feedback, a “thank you” and “confirmation” page will display, notifying students that their feedback has been received. It also has links to other web pages such as the “FAQ” and the “Recipe and Meals Suggestions.”

SMITH COLLEGE Discover Smith Academics Admission & Aid Your Campus News & Events

Home > Your Campus > Dining & Menus

Anonymous Student Feedback

House Menus > Hours > Sustainability > **Current Students** > Campus Center Café > Catering > Our Team >

< Back

Anonymous Student Feedback

We appreciate any and all feedback. Please leave your thoughts below. If you would like us to follow up on your feedback, please enter your email, and we will reach out to you as soon as possible.

OPTIONAL - If you would like us to follow up on your feedback, please leave your email:

Student Feedback:

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Submit Feedback

Figure 16

The “Recipe and Meal Suggestions” page allows students to suggest specific meals and recipes that could be incorporated into future menus at Smith. For this section of the prototype,

we focused on addressing the pain points of our Design Fiction Scenario (Figure 6), and the user persona “Estella” (Figure 5)

To create a familiar experience for students, we implemented the UI of popular student apps such as Reddit and Confesh. When students click into specific threads, they can engage with the post by commenting, responding, and liking the post (Figure 17). Students can also see if the dining staff has responded to each thread and the status of those requests. Students are of course able to create new threads with suggestions. Our prototype took inspiration from our Design Fiction Scenario, using Estella's request for Mapo Tofu as the prime example. Students can express their reasoning for their suggestion, give advice on making the meal on a large scale, or even just link potential recipes for dining workers to learn from (Figure 18).

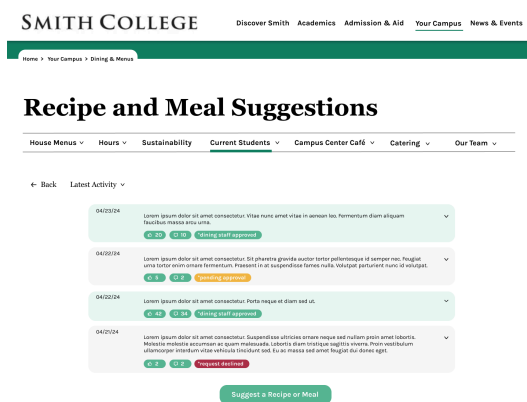


Figure 17

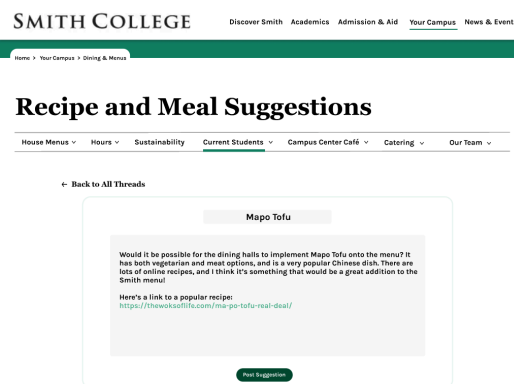


Figure 18

With these new additions to the website prototype, we hope to foster greater communication between Smith's students and staff to improve the dining experience. By including aspects of social media on the existing website, we maintain familiarity for students and encourage collaboration in improving Smith's Dining Halls. We understand that the dining staff cares about the Smith student body and wants everyone to have the best experience possible. With this in mind, we also implemented perspectives and UI specifically for the dining staff.

Since we wanted to create an online space where students and staff could create mutual communication and understanding, it was important for us to find ways to make the staff experience on the website comfortable and not overwhelming with inquiries. To do this we first established a secure login for staff once they enter the “Student Inquires” page within the “Our Team” tab which is modeled by the student Moodle login page. This way staff feel comfortable knowing that they are the only ones that have access to the more direct student feedback. Once they enter their unique staff-specific credentials (which we assume they have) they are then met with two page options either entering the “Student Feedback” section or the “Recipe and Meal Suggestions” section (Figure 19).

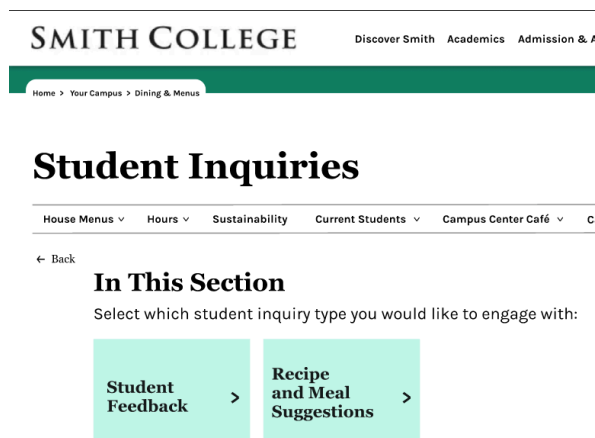


Figure 19

If they choose to enter the “Student Feedback” section they will need to select the house that they work in to view house-specific inquiries (Figure 20). Once they select their house they can view different inquiry topics submitted by students which include the “Food quality”, “Facilities and Ambiance”, “Staff and Services”, “General Feedback”, and “FAQ” options (Figure 21). We decided to split up the inquiries into specific topic pages because we did not want the workers to enter this page and become overwhelmed by a wall of text or a random mix of different inquiry types that may be confusing to read. If a worker enters any of these topic pages they are met with an organized list of inquiries that are categorized as read and unread. The read comments are changed to color green with a status update to read. These read comments are also placed on the read stack which moves all the unread inquiries to the top. Meanwhile, the unread comments are grayed out so they call attention to the staff member and they are able to distinguish between what has already been engaged with by other staff (Figure 22). These comments also have an additional feature where a reply button is present. If this button’s text is whitened out that means the student did not leave their email for further commentary from staff, but if they did leave their email then it is blacked out. In the case of a blacked-out button, a staff member can go into the message and type a reply back which will be anonymously sent to the student’s email inbox via a general dining staff email. It is important to note that the student’s email information is not shown in any part of this process to keep their anonymity.

Student Feedback

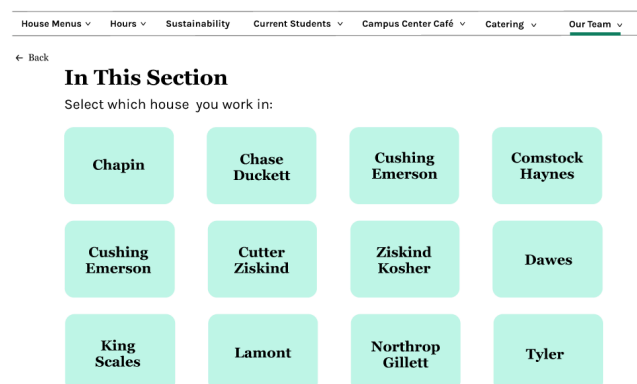


Figure 20

Student Inquiries

House Menus > Hours > Sustainability > Current Students > Campus Center Café > Catering > Our Team >

← Back

In This Section

Select which feedback type you would like to engage with:



Figure 21

Going back to the original two-page options a staff member can also go into the “Recipe and Meals Suggestions” forum. When they enter this page they are met with a similar view to the student perspective, but there are two key differences. The first is that they are able to comment on the thread with a different profile header. While students have the header of “Anonymous” staff have “[Dining Staff Member]” with a distinct font color of green to highlight them within discussion threads (Figure 23). This distinction allows for students to know that a dining worker has seen and engaged with their recipe which will ideally foster mutual respect and communication. The second difference is the ability of staff to change the status of meal suggestions from pending approval to dining staff approved or request declined (Figure 24). Ideally, when a staff member updates the status of the meal they will also comment on why they approved or declined certain meals to foster transparency within the community. Ultimately this new design helps address both student and faculty perspectives on dining while allowing for respectful, transparent, and collaborative communication between both parties.

Recipe and Meal Suggestions

House Menus > Hours > Sustainability > Current Students > Campus Center Café > Catering > Our Team >

← Back to All Threads

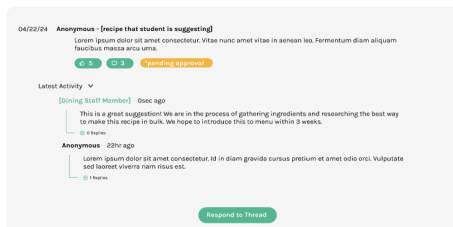


Figure 23

Food Quality

House Menus > Hours > Sustainability > Current Students > Campus Center Café > Catering > Our Team >

← Back

Latest Activity >

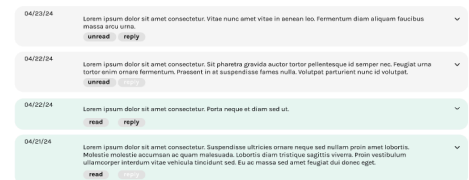


Figure 22

Recipe and Meal Suggestions

House Menus > Hours > Sustainability > Current Students > Campus Center Café > Catering > Our Team >

← Back to All Threads

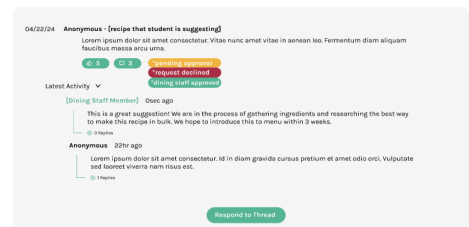


Figure 24

6. Evaluation Method & Results

We evaluated our prototype with the feedback we received from our peers. We reached out to people outside of the classroom to interact with it during the developmental phase and after. Our major resource was the feedback we received during Demo day from the professor & students. Once they interacted with the prototype, they commented on how much our website looked like the current Smith website. The professor commented on the same design choice, saying that it would allow for a smooth integration into the existing website.

One thing we learned was the importance of anonymity in building a less hostile design that could have real-life repercussions. Our first instinct in our design process was to put names on the dining workers to give credit to the workers who are rarely seen by the student body. The feedback we received in class made us aware that this design choice would not be empathetic to the staff, as students could take advantage of their own anonymity and send harsh feedback to dining staff members who do not have control over all aspects of the dining experience. We changed our design to allow the staff to remain anonymous if they wish. We also implemented a log-in page to certify that they are staff and to ensure students won't have the same access and capabilities to respond to threads and comments as the staff would.

Throughout our design process, we focused on POC & international students. By designing with these students' pain points in mind, we created something that can benefit the whole Smith student body. Rather than a more specific design that will help those of our chosen site, we saw an opportunity to integrate our design into the way all students interact with the dining website. We saw how receptive our white peers were to the design, as they also experienced dissatisfaction with Smith Dining. By creating a way to increase communication between all students, the dining experience can be more inclusive and greatly improved.

7. Conclusion

What others can draw from this case study is the need for communication between students and dining workers in our college. The current effort to integrate other cuisines into the menu has not been successful. POC and International Students do not connect with cultural and ethnic foods because they are not made authentically. These students reported that it reminded them that they were in a predominantly white space, despite the good intentions behind the dining choices. They voiced that they wanted to contribute to the dining experience, but there wasn't a way to communicate effectively with the staff. This case study shows the need for a line of communication between the staff and students to increase satisfaction.

Our next steps would be to have Smith Dining Staff evaluate and test our design. They would bring valuable insight into the dining experience that would be essential for an effective design. Our main priority with this design was to make it easy to integrate into existing designs and systems. Therefore, we want to know more about the worker's experience and revise our design as needed to address their concerns and pain points.